

Online Consumer Engagement: Scopus-Based Systematic Review and Future Research Directions

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Abstract- *Online consumer engagement, also known as digital consumer engagement, is crucial for understanding different contexts and identifying potential outcomes for both academic and practical implications. It enriches studies related to business, management, finance, and accounting. Hence, to examine the trends, meanings, determinants, and outcomes of online consumer engagement, and to provide a conceptual framework for future research, this paper follows a systematic literature review process in line with PRISMA 2020 guidelines, based on articles published in the Scopus database over the last ten years. The findings suggest that online consumer engagement is a multidimensional construct divided into behavioural, cognitive, emotional, and social dimensions, which is influenced by content-related factors, firm and platform strategies, consumer characteristics, and social influences. Engagement outcomes are categorised from immediate behavioural responses to longer-term relational and performance-related effects. The conceptual framework prepared based on the findings will be helpful for academicians as well as businesses in understanding the factors that may influence consumer engagement in the digital landscape and the outcomes that may be derived from engaged consumers.*

Keywords: *Online consumer engagement, digital consumer engagement, systematic literature review, determinants of online consumer engagement, outcomes of online consumer engagement.*

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1. Introduction- In the present digital era, people spend a considerable amount of time online, not only for entertainment but also for making important decisions such as purchasing products and services. In India, nearly 70 per cent of the population uses social media or other online platforms (Smart Insights, 2025). As a result, online platforms have become an important space where firms and consumers interact. Consumer engagement refers to the level of involvement or interest shown by consumers while interacting with a brand's social media pages or online platforms. This engagement can be observed through consumers' feelings, thoughts, and actions, such as liking posts, commenting, sharing content, or watching videos (Srivastava et al., 2025). With the growing focus on omnichannel strategies, businesses are increasingly targeting consumers across multiple online platforms to enhance their engagement experience. Therefore, increasing and maintaining consumer engagement has become a key concern for online marketers.

Online consumer engagement is not only central to marketing outcomes but also holds significance across disciplines such as psychology, sociology, and organisational behaviour, where it is studied as a driver of value co-creation, relationship building, and active participation in digital ecosystems (Singh et al., 2024)

Consumer engagement is a multidimensional concept that serves both as an outcome of marketing efforts and as a determinant of other online marketing outcomes (Srivastava et al., 2025). There is a gap in consolidated findings on antecedents, outcomes and definitions of online consumer engagement. To address this gap, the present study aims to systematically review prior research using the Scopus database and PRISMA guidelines. The purpose of this study is to define conceptual dimensions of online consumer engagement, identify its key antecedents, and analyse major outcomes, thereby offering a structured synthesis and directions for future research.

Hence, this study aims to address the following research questions:

RQ1: What are the publication trends in online consumer engagement research?

RQ2: What antecedents influence online consumer engagement?

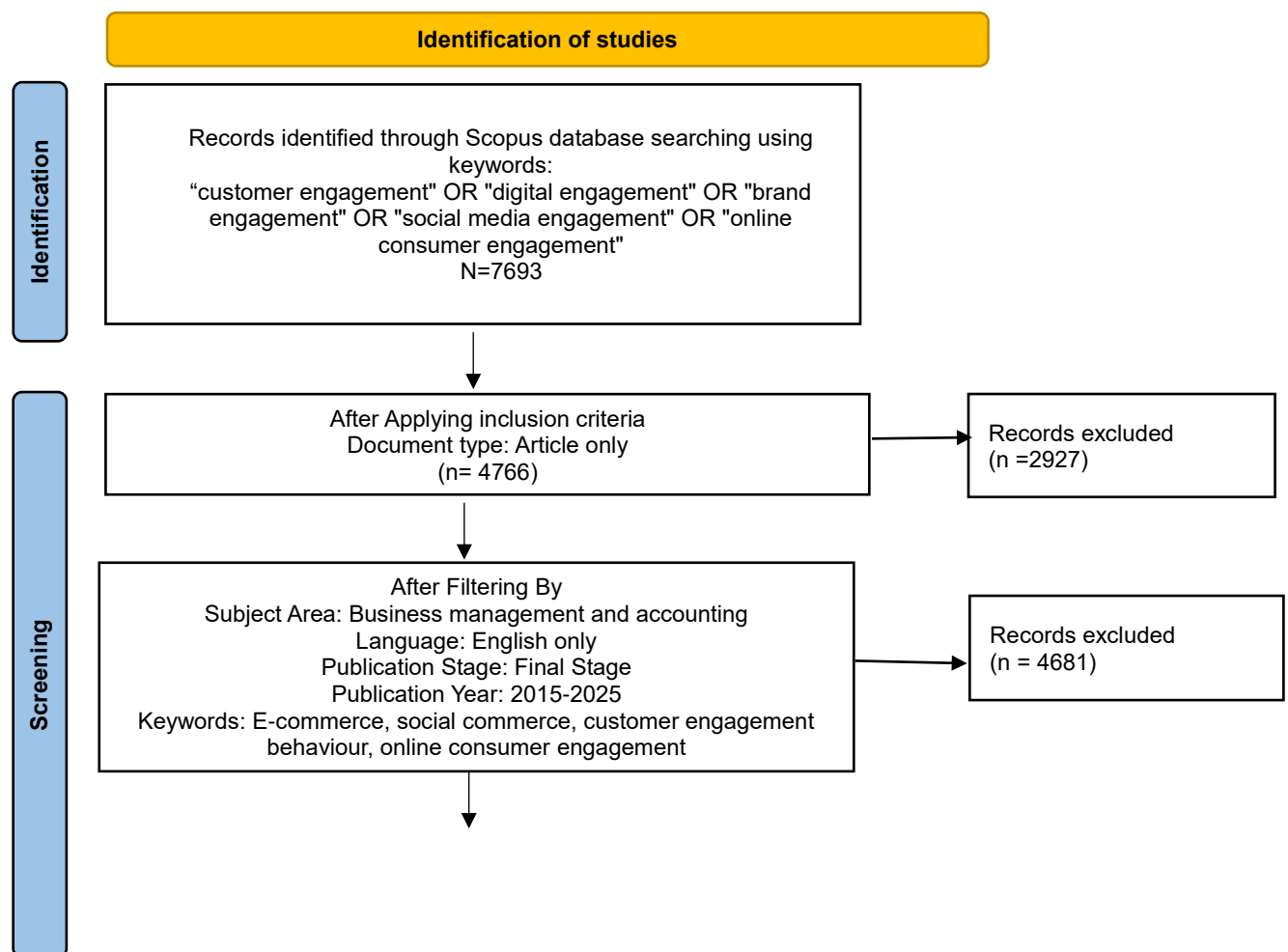
RQ3: What outcomes are associated with online consumer engagement?

Accordingly, this review has three **objectives**: to examine publication trends in online consumer engagement research, to identify the antecedents influencing online consumer engagement, and to synthesise the outcomes associated with online consumer engagement across different contexts and to propose a conceptual framework based on the findings for future research. To answer the research questions, the structure of this study is as follows: the next section describes the methodology used for the literature review, followed by an in-depth analysis and synthesis of the selected studies. The concluding sections discuss the findings, highlight limitations, propose future research directions, and present the overall conclusion.

2. Research Methodology- This study follows a systematic literature review approach guided by the Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses (PRISMA)

framework. An SLR is used when the objective of the review is to do content analysis. A systematic review was selected as it allows a structured and transparent way to identify, screen, and review existing studies, while reducing the possibility of bias (Shamseer et al 2024). This approach is useful when research findings are scattered across different studies and need to be brought together in a meaningful way (Agrawal et al 2024). Compared to narrative reviews, a systematic review provides better clarity and consistency, making it suitable for the present study.

The Scopus database was used as the primary source of data because of its wide coverage of peer-reviewed journals in marketing, management, and related areas (Chadegani et al 2013; Shaheen, H., 2025). The selection of studies was carried out following the PRISMA process, which includes identification, screening, eligibility assessment, and final inclusion of relevant articles. PRISMA is a structured review protocol which provides a four-phase flow diagram representing sample identification for screening and then for eligibility testing and the final demonstration of the studies included in the review (Page et al., 2021). There are three main steps to conducting an SLR: determining the search strategy, establishing document selection with inclusion/exclusion criteria, and analysing based on the research question (Riandhi et al., 2021). At the initial stage, all similar terms related to consumer engagement were searched in the Scopus database, and after applying several inclusion criteria, 4766 documents remained for further screening. In an SLR, it is necessary to focus on a specific topic or keyword to avoid information overload (Pittaway et al., 2004) and hence using appropriate keywords is necessary to get the most directly relevant documents to serve the purpose of the study. Therefore, the complete selection process, along with exclusion and inclusion criteria at each stage, is presented in Figure 1.



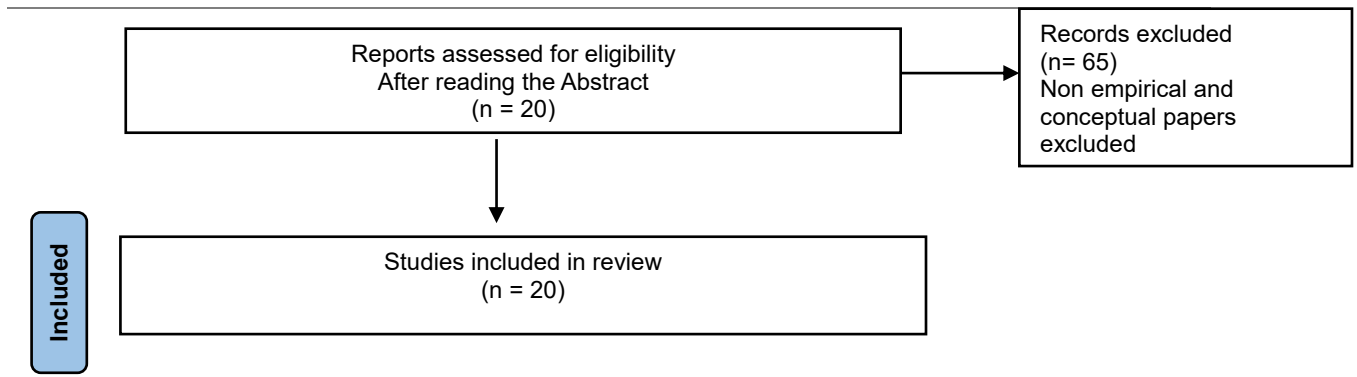


Figure 1: Presents a summary of the study selection process followed in accordance with the PRISMA guidelines(2020)

3. Results- This section is further divided into three parts: understanding the trend of the studies on online consumer engagement, how it has been defined in various studies, and what the dependent and independent variables used in different studies and outcomes of online consumer engagement are in different contexts to provide an understanding of its diversified scope.

3.1 Descriptive Analysis of the Selected Studies- This subsection presents a descriptive overview of the studies included in the review, focusing on publication trends over time, country-wise distribution, and subject-area classification.

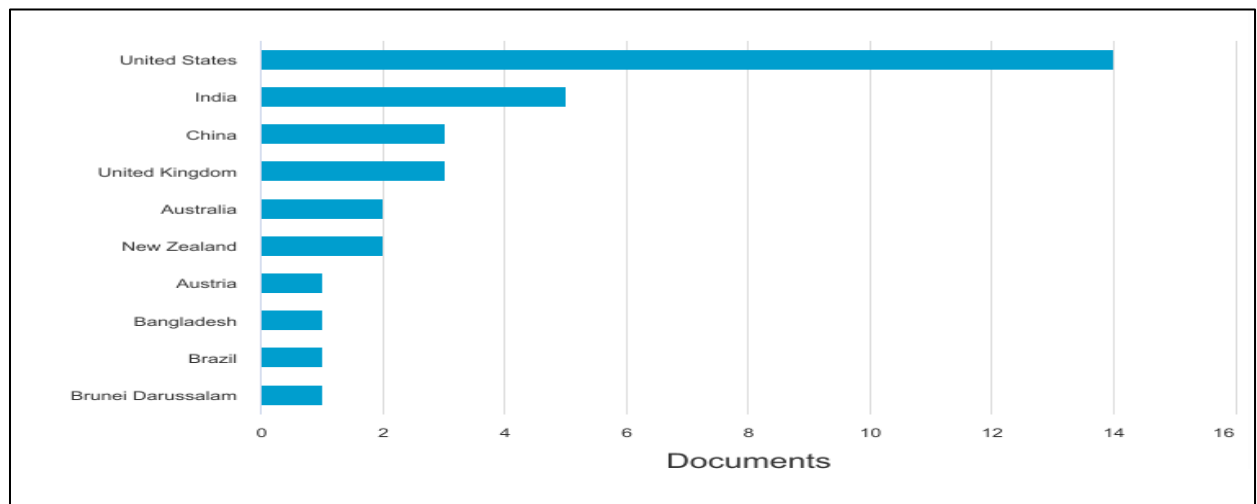


Figure 2: Country-wise publication (source: Scopus Database)

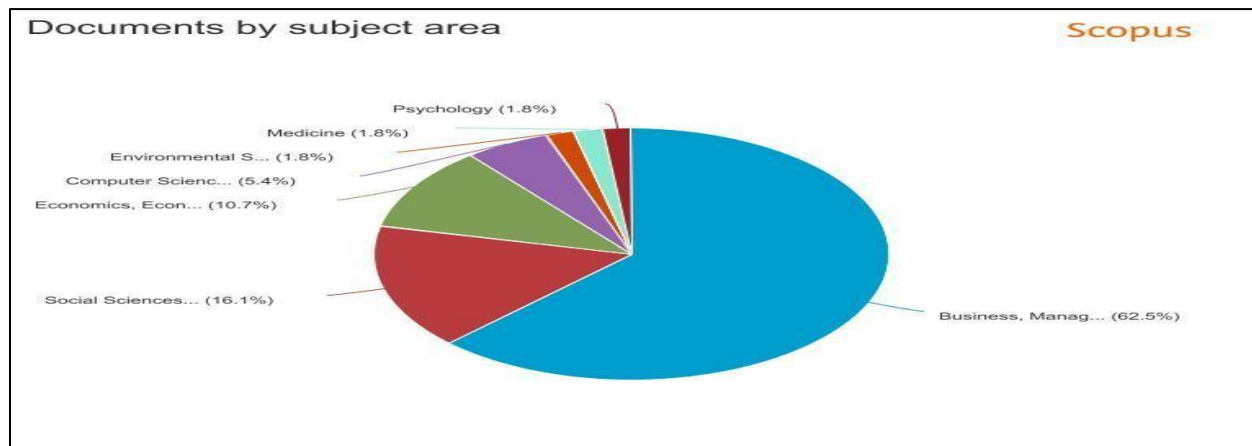


Figure 3: Subject-wise publication of online consumer engagement(source: Scopus Database)

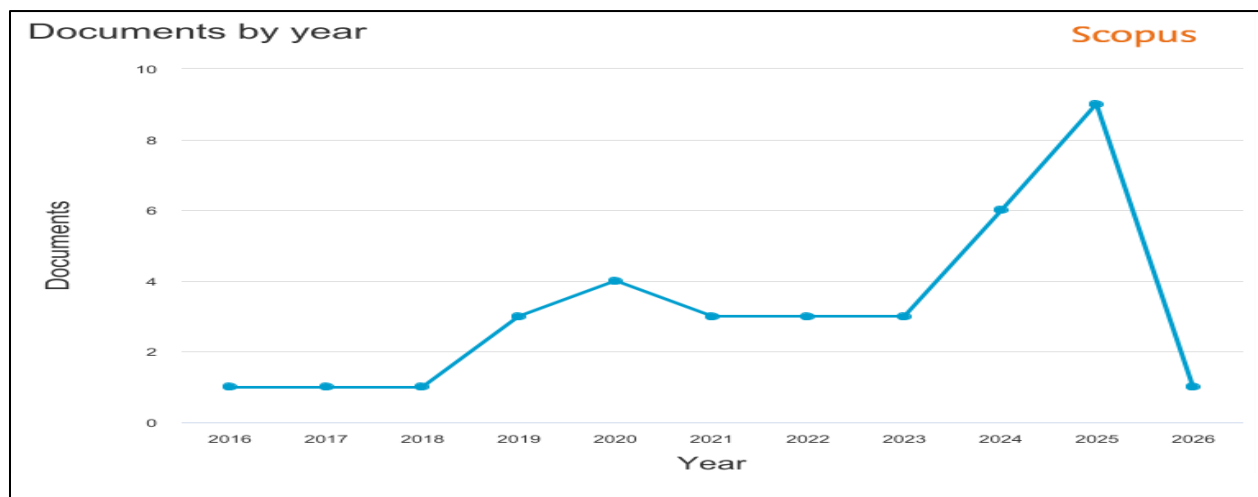


Figure 4: Year-wise publication of online consumer engagement (source: Scopus Database)

Figure 1 presents the country-wise distribution of the selected studies, highlighting that research is mainly concentrated in a limited number of countries. Figure 2 depicts the subject area distribution, with most studies published in the fields of business, management, and accounting. Figure 3 shows the year-wise publication trend of studies on online consumer engagement, indicating a gradual increase in research output after 2015 and a noticeable rise in recent years.

3.2 Conceptualisation of Online Consumer Engagement- Online consumer engagement is defined in the literature in several related but distinct ways, depending on the research context and digital platform. Many studies conceptualise online consumer engagement as observable digital interactions, such as likes, comments, shares, views, impressions, and clicks in response to brand or influencer content on social media. This behavioural approach is widely used in research on influencer marketing, sustainability communication, diversity, equity, and inclusion messaging, financial technology communication, and greenwashing, where engagement reflects consumers' visible reactions to online content (Ndasi and Cheung, 2026; Munaro et al., 2024; Shabbir Husain et al., 2024; Topal et al., 2020).

Other studies describe online consumer engagement as socially expressive participation in digital environments. In omnichannel retailing and online brand community research, engagement includes behaviours such as online deal-content sharing, user-generated content, advocacy, and co-creation, which support electronic word of mouth and interaction among consumers (Pai et al., 2025; Paintsil and Kim, 2022; Cheng et al., 2021).

A broader stream of research defines online consumer engagement as a multidimensional construct that includes cognitive, emotional, and behavioural dimensions. From this perspective, engagement involves consumers' attention, interest, enjoyment, identification, and active participation with digital brand content, rather than only observable actions (Rasty and Filieri, 2024; Marbach et al., 2019; Islam et al., 2017).

In digital service settings, online consumer engagement is often defined as active use of digital platforms, for example, electronic payment systems and insurance portals. In these contexts, digital awareness, digital literacy, and continuous interaction all reflect engagement and contribute to consumer empowerment, perceived value, adoption intention, and customer retention (Gupta and Prusty, 2024; Singh et al., 2024). Therefore, all available studies support the argument that online consumer engagement is context-dependent and can be measured through observable digital behaviours with psychological involvement and motivational determinants.

3.3 Determinants and Outcomes of Online Consumer Engagement – The present studies different categories of determinants that affect online consumer engagement and that result in outcomes that can further result in stages of consumer outcomes beginning with immediate behaviour response, relationship building and relational benefits that may affect measurable commercial impact. Determinants of engagement may be categorised into the following factors-

3.3.1. Determinants of Engagement

- *Content and Platform Factors:* Content characteristics, specifically storytelling and narrative quality, enhance engagement by capturing attention and increasing sharing intentions (Coker et al., 2021). For instance, storytelling-based video advertisements outperform argumentative formats in driving behavioural engagement (Coker et al., 2021). Studies further argue that the type of firm-generated content significantly dictates the level of consumer interaction and subsequent firm performance (Cheng et al., 2021). Consumer engagement may also be affected through various contextual platform events and how brands frame their message, and their responses to greenwashing (Topal et al., 2020).
- *Consumer and social factors:* several empirical studies show that personality traits, including extraversion, openness and agreeableness, positively influence engagement in online brand communities, with personal values moderating these relationships (Marbach et al., 2019; Islam et al., 2017). Since consumers are part of society, the society they belong to also shapes how they interact in the online environment. Findings of studies even support the assumption that reference group impact emotional engagement through informational and value-expressive pathways

more than pure utilitarian pressure (Wei & Murshed, 2019). However, due to individual differences, the intensity of engagement may vary dramatically across individuals, with different engagement types identified among specific demographic cohorts such as millennials (Rissanen & Luoma-Aho, 2016).

3.3.2. Outcomes of Online Customer Engagement: Businesses are adopting omnichannel strategies these days to attract customers because of their several direct and indirect advantages. For instance, social media communities positively contribute to customer consumption, specifically in terms of new customer acquisition and existing customer retention (Ho et al., 2020). However, the outcomes of online customer engagement can not always be directly measured through sales performance alone. As per the existing literature, the outcomes of customer engagement may be categorised into three types-

- **Immediate Behavioural Outcomes:** Customer engagement may lead to short-term immediate digital actions observed through increased likes, shares, comments and immediate visit or purchase intentions (Ndasi & Cheung, 2026; Munaro et al., 2024; Singh et al., 2024).
- **Relational Outcomes:** Online customer engagement also helps to strengthen relationship quality with the brand or sellers on social commerce platforms. Studies highlight that if engagement is sustained, then sharing of user-generated content by the users results in deeper psychological bonds, which may further lead to enhanced brand knowledge, positive electronic word of mouth (e-WOM), advocacy and long-term brand trust and loyalty (Paintsil & Kim, 2022; Pai et al., 2025; Sharma et al., 2019).
- **Performance Outcomes:** The main advantage of having favourable online customer engagement for business is to translate these relational and behavioural outcomes into tangible firm performance, observed through higher digital service adoption rates, customer retention and overall sales (Gupta & Prusty, 2024; Cheng et al., 2021).

4. Discussion

The findings of this review indicate that online consumer engagement is a multidimensional construct encompassing behavioural, cognitive, emotional and social dimensions. To summarise these findings theoretically, the proposed conceptual framework is grounded in the Stimulus-Organism-Response (S-O-R) model (Mehrabian & Russell, 1974). The SOR model is widely applied in environmental and marketing psychology to explain how external cues shape internal states and then behavioural outcomes (Peng et al., 2014). Applying the SOR approach to online consumer engagement provides a theoretically robust framework that connects the antecedents (stimuli) across all selected empirical studies included for review with the internal, multidimensional engagement state (organism) and the outcomes (Response).

4.1 Stimuli (S): Antecedents of Online Consumer Engagement

The reviewed literature combines four broad categories of external stimuli that affect online consumer engagement. **First, Content-related stimuli**, which include storytelling and narrative quality, message framing, and personalisation, capture attention and increase sharing and

recommendation behaviour (Coker et al., 2021; Suseno & Nguyen, 2023; Zhang et al., 2024). **Second**, *Firm and platform-related stimuli*, which include firm-generated content strategies and the design of digital platforms and services, shape the intensity of engagement and link it to firm performance (Cheng et al., 2021; Gupta & Prusty, 2024; Singh et al., 2024). **Third**, *Social stimuli* that includes reference-group pressure, influencer type and messaging, and broader cultural or societal attitudes that condition how consumers respond to online content, observed through cross-country variation in reactions to greenwashing (Wei & Murshed, 2019; Ndasi & Cheung, 2026; Topal et al., 2020), and **fourth**, *consumer-attribute stimuli* which refer to relatively stable determinants affected by individual differences such as personality traits, personal values, and pre-existing engagement dispositions, that determine how consumers processes these external cues and how strongly they respond (Marbach et al., 2019; Islam et al., 2017; Rissanen & Luoma-Aho, 2016). Together, all these four stimulus categories function as environmental cues that affect the internal engagement process.

4.2 Organism (O): The Internal, Multidimensional Engagement State

Within the S-O-R paradigm, the Organism represents the internal, largely unobservable psychological state that mediates the relationship between stimuli and response (Mehrabian & Russell, 1974). The reviewed studies converge on four interrelated dimensions of this internal state in the online consumer engagement context. **Cognitive engagement** reflects consumers' attention, interest, and information-processing effort directed toward brand content (Rasty & Filieri, 2024; Islam et al., 2017). **Emotional engagement** captures affective responses such as enjoyment, identification, and attachment that develop through interaction with content and communities (Marbach et al., 2019; Paintsil & Kim, 2022; Wei & Murshed, 2019). **Behavioural engagement**, the most frequently operationalised dimension in the reviewed literature, is expressed through observable digital actions such as liking, commenting, sharing, and viewing (Ndasi & Cheung, 2026; Munaro et al., 2024; ShabbirHusain et al., 2024). **Social engagement** further expands beyond individual behaviour, resulting in co-creation, participation, and advocacy with brand communities (Pai et al., 2025; Paintsil & Kim, 2022; Cheng et al., 2021). These dimensions should neither be treated as independent nor always sequential, they may be best studied as concurrently activated but mutually reinforcing in a layered manner. This internal state, once activated, results in a hierarchy of outcomes rather than a single set of effects.

4.3 Response (R): The Hierarchy of Engagement Outcomes

In the SOR model, response is the set of outcomes which results due to external cues and internal psychological processing. In the context of online consumer engagement, the outcomes identified across reviewed studies are organised in distinct but interrelated stages. *The first* layer consists of immediate behavioural responses such as visiting a platform, adopting an e-payment system, or making a purchase, which is the result of the activated organism state (Gupta & Prusty, 2024; Singh et al., 2024; Ndasi & Cheung, 2026). Then, in *the second stage*, relational responses strengthen through a series of repeated engagements, trust, brand loyalty and positive e-WOM or advocacy by consumers (Sharma et al., 2019; Islam et al., 2017; Paintsil & Kim, 2022; Coker et al., 2021). *Then finally, the third and most crucial layer*, which may be sustained for the long term, consists of performance responses at the firm level, such as

sales and customer retention (Cheng et al., 2021; Singh et al., 2024). All these layers are successive stages along with a single engagement-to-value pathway, moving from immediate action to long-term relational and performance impact.

4.4 Thematic integration of variables into SOR framework and applicability limits

As discussed earlier, the four stimulus categories, such as content, firm, platform, social and consumer attributes, can together or independently activate the internal and organism state observed through cognitive, emotional, behavioural and social dimensions of engagement described earlier; this organism state is then expressed through a hierarchy of responses that begins with immediate behavioural response to long-term relational outcomes, which may finally lead to firm-level performance outcomes. This integration provides the explanatory, theory-grounded pathways connecting specific antecedents to their outcomes in different cultural and geographic contexts, addressing the critical gap highlighted in engagement literature (Shu et al. 2025; Lee et al. 2022). The present findings not only suggest studying the relation between online consumer engagement with antecedents and outcomes through an S-O-R lens but also provide literature support from the collective insights of all selected quantitative studies from different contexts.

However, as the framework is derived from a synthesis of predominantly cross-sectional and single-platform data, it must therefore be studied as a set of conceptual propositions rather than an established empirical model. The relation may differ if studied in different contexts; for instance, behavioural response is not only an outcome but can also serve as a stimulus and affect the relations in future research.

Stimulus (S)	Organism (O)	Response (R)
<i>Content-related factors:</i> <i>storytelling, message framing, personalisation</i>	<i>Cognitive engagement:</i> <i>attention, interest, information processing</i>	<i>Immediate behavioural outcomes:</i> <i>likes, shares, visit/purchase intention</i>
<i>Firm/platform factors:</i> <i>firm-generated content, platform features, digital service design</i>	<i>Emotional engagement:</i> <i>enjoyment, identification, attachment</i>	<i>Relational outcomes:</i> <i>trust, loyalty, advocacy, e-WOM</i>
<i>Social influences:</i> <i>reference groups, influencer type, cultural/societal norms</i>	<i>Behavioural engagement:</i> <i>liking, commenting, sharing</i>	<i>Performance outcomes:</i> <i>sales, retention, firm performance</i>
<i>Consumer attributes:</i> <i>personality traits, personal values, engagement disposition</i>	<i>Social engagement:</i> <i>co-creation, advocacy, community participation</i>	

Figure 5: S-O-R Variable Mapping of Online Consumer Engagement (author's compilation)

5. Limitations and Future Research Directions- This study provides a synthesis of systematic online consumer engagement, but has some limitations that suggest future review papers need to address. Future studies may consider other databases such as Web of Science, and the

selection of other subject areas may help to get deeper insights into this subject. Due to the small sample size, this study also restricts generalizability, which can be addressed by future researchers by considering qualitative studies also to review the available literature on online consumer engagement. Moreover, in available empirical studies, it is also observed that more emphasis is on behavioural engagement, with limited focus on cognitive, emotional and relational aspects. Hence, to fill all these gaps, future studies should broaden the database across different contexts, adopting cross-sectional and longitudinal methods, and empirically test the proposed framework to strengthen theory and practice.

6. Conclusion- This study presents a PRISMA-guided systematic review of online consumer engagement, synthesising its key antecedents, multidimensional conceptualisations, and outcomes. The findings show that online consumer engagement is shaped by content, firm and platform strategies, consumer characteristics, and social influences, and that leads to important behavioural and relational outcomes. By integrating fragmented literature and proposing a conceptual framework, this review offers a clear foundation for future research and practical digital engagement strategies.

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